STUDIO OPERATIONS

The Client Said Yes. What Did They Buy?

The decisions a proposal needs to make visible before a fee becomes a promise.



Fran Herrera · Co-founder, Strategy & Operations
Updated November 14, 2026 · 5 min read

The hotel owner approves your proposal for a lighting redesign. The fee is $48,000. Two weeks later, the operator asks when your team will program the scenes and train the evening staff. Your designer thought programming would sit with the controls contractor. The owner remembers a slide showing the room at breakfast, dinner, and late at night. To her, your team sold the change she saw in those images.

The proposal took three days to write. In the kickoff, a single question changes how the team will staff the job, who it needs to bring in, and how much of the fee is left for design.

Before writing a project proposal, decide what the client is buying, what the price assumes, who does the work your offer depends on, and which choices remain open. If there's a real uncertainty, give the client a way to resolve it before they commit to a price or date that depends on it.

Which decisions have to be made before the fee goes on the page?

Start with the result the client expects to be able to use. Work backward through the deliverables, related responsibilities, inputs, and decisions required. Write the scope in terms the client can confirm, including work handled by someone else.

AIA's B101 owner–architect agreement distinguishes basic, supplemental, and additional services. It also describes basic work across phases, from schematic design through construction-phase services. That structure gives a commercial conversation somewhere to go when two people say "design" and each expects a different level of involvement. AIA on the architect's basic services · AIA B101 overview

For the hotel, ask how the operator will know the lighting is ready. "We can call up a dinner setting at the host stand and change it after service" is a testable condition. The proposal can say who selects the fixtures, who checks the controls configuration, who programs the scenes, and who trains staff. If someone else supplies that work, show the dependency alongside your own scope so the owner can account for it before accepting.

When should you offer a first phase or two options?

Offer a first phase when investigation is needed before a reliable commitment. Offer options when the choices can already be described and each has a clear consequence for the client. A price with a defined condition can also work if the client knows which decision would change it.

Think about trading in an iPhone. Apple gives you an estimate based on the condition you describe. If inspection finds something different, the value can change. Apple says you can decline a lower revised offer. The decision is clear before you send the phone. You know what the initial number assumes, what will be checked, and what you can do if the amount changes. A hotel proposal can be equally explicit about an unverified controls system. Apple Trade In, inspection and revised offers

Situation before the hotel proposal	What a buyer can reasonably approve
Nobody has verified whether the existing system can support the intended scenes.	A short paid investigation with an output and a decision about whether to reuse or replace controls.
A controls partner can handle implementation and has defined its scope.	A design fee with clear responsibilities and a separate, priced implementation option if available.
The operator wants staff training but has yet to decide how many locations to include.	A base scope with the first location defined, plus the basis for adding other locations.

Compare proposals by what the buyer can safely say yes to. A discovery phase may help a client who has genuine unknowns. It can also frustrate a buyer who has already supplied reliable records and needs a decision now. Ask which missing fact would materially change price, timing, or responsibility. That's the reason to phase the work.

How do you check whether the buyer understood the proposal?

Ask someone unfamiliar with the draft to explain what the client will receive, what the client still has to provide, and what changes the fee. Use the same check with the person who will deliver the job. Fix any material difference before the proposal becomes the starting point for a contract.

The **Proposal Preparation Record** can be six lines. For the hotel: desired result, dinner scenes the staff can operate. Deliverables, layout and specification plus a review of the controls sequence. Client inputs, controls drawings and operating requirements. Open assumption, compatibility with installed equipment. Responsible specialists, design lead and named controls partner. Requested decision, approve design scope or include the priced commissioning option. Those six lines are also the first useful record for the kickoff.

One more test. Read the page where the price appears without the rest of the presentation. Would the reader be able to tell whether site visits and commissioning are in the figure? Put any answer that could change the buying decision where people see it before they sign.

Three details to carry from proposal into delivery.

- State what the buyer will be able to use at the end.

- Name who performs dependent work and what happens if the assumption changes.
- Keep the accepted scope and the open decisions together for the team that starts the job.

When the operator asks about training at kickoff, your project lead can open the same proposal the owner approved. The next conversation can be about dates and staff, with the responsibility already clear.

Frequently asked questions

Can I send a proposal when the client hasn't made every decision?

Yes, if the client can see what is priced and what remains conditional. Give each unresolved decision an owner and explain which parts of the offer it can change.

What can a firm safely reuse between proposals?

Reuse the structure and the language for genuinely standard terms. Confirm deliverables, site assumptions, outside responsibilities, fees, and deadlines for the specific engagement.

Who should review a proposal before it goes out?

Include someone who will deliver the work and someone who can approve the commercial terms. Review should focus on what the client could reasonably believe the team has promised.

The hotel scenario and its price are illustrative. The AIA and Apple examples draw on public documentation.